

Practice Paper 18 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Relationship with her body

1 mark for identifying that the narrator **personifies her legs** / treats her body as a **separate, complaining party**.

1 mark for the **parent–child dynamic**: she is the calm authority humouring an irritable subordinate, suggesting she is **forcing herself to stay in control** even as her body protests.

Sample answer: The narrator personifies her legs as if they were another person, and casts herself as the patient adult dealing with a **tired child**. This suggests that she is treating her own body as a separate, complaining party that must be **managed** rather than obeyed.

Q2. [2] — Two details showing how far behind she was

1 mark each for any two of:

- “The fast runners had long since vanished into rumour” (so far ahead they have become almost legendary).
- The middle of the field “had thinned, then dispersed”.
- The few ahead “appeared... to be walking” because they were so far down the avenue.
- “Behind me there was nothing” — no one was even behind her.

Reject: general lifts that do not show **distance** (e.g. “the road had emptied” alone).

Q3. [2] — “Humiliation in being the reason a finish line is still standing”

1 mark — She feels embarrassed because the marathon equipment (barriers, water station, bunting) would already have been packed away if not for her.

1 mark — Her **slowness** is **holding up** volunteers and staff, making her presence feel like an **inconvenience** / a **public exposure of her failure to keep pace**.

Q4. [1] — Volunteer’s “small” and “tired” smile

1 mark — It suggests the volunteers have been on duty for many hours and are **exhausted** / **ready to go home**, and that the smile, though kind, is **strained** / **not genuine cheer**. (Also accept: it shows the event has dragged on far longer than expected.)

Q5. [2] — The honest answer

(a) [1]: The honest answer is that she is doing the marathon **for herself** / for her own sake, not for any audience or family member.

(b) [1]: At this point she is **exhausted, alone, and last; self-motivation** feels **thin and inadequate** when there is no external reward or witness to push her on.

Q6. [2] — Italics on “next to”

1 mark — The italics **emphasise the distinction** between **running with** (which would imply companionship, conversation, joint effort) and **running next to** (which is **purely physical proximity**, without intrusion).

1 mark — It highlights the **quiet, undemanding nature** of the stranger’s kindness — he offers his pace without claiming her attention or asking anything of her.

Q7. [3] — Impression of the elderly stranger

1 mark for a clear character impression: **quietly kind, humble, experienced, unassuming, generous**.

1 mark each for **two** supporting details from Paragraph 5 (max 2). Accept any two of:

- His “faded blue shorts and a plain white singlet” — unshowy, modest clothing.
- “He did not look across. He did not speak.” — he respects her privacy and does not seek attention.
- “The easy economy of someone who had done this many times” — he is experienced.
- He held the pace “as though it were a small and obvious courtesy” — generous without making a fuss.

Each detail must be **quoted or clearly referenced** and **explained**; mere lifting = ½ mark.

Q8. [2] — How the stranger’s presence helped (own words)

1 mark — The **rhythm** of their two pairs of feet moving in step **steadied** / **regulated her breathing** in a way she could not achieve on her own.

1 mark — His silent companionship **quietened the protest** of her tired legs / made the effort feel **more bearable** for a short stretch.

Reject answers that lift “did something to my breathing” without rewording.

Q9. [1] — Detail supporting “a sad little affair”

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- “A rope between two cones”.
- “A digital clock blinking apologetically”.
- “A single bored official with a clipboard”.

Q10. [2] — “A stubbornness I had not previously credited myself with”

1 mark — She has discovered an **unexpected toughness / determination** in herself that she did not know she possessed.

1 mark — The phrase shows her **new self-respect**: she has revised her view of herself **upwards**, recognising a quality she had not given herself credit for before this race.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **quietly satisfied, reflective, grateful, accepting, humbled**. (Reject: **triumphant, bitter, sad** — these miss the calm, modest quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [1] — Attitude towards “weightless consumption”

1 mark — The writer is **sceptical** / **dismissive** of this impression. He believes it is a **misleading appearance** — streaming only **feels** weightless because its true infrastructure is hidden from view. (Also accept: **critical**, **unconvinced**.)

Q13. [2] — Parts of the streaming infrastructure

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Data centres.**
- **Undersea cables.**
- **Home routers.**

Q14. [2] — “Unusually noisy” academic argument (own words)

1 mark — The disagreement among researchers has been **unusually loud** / **public** / **heated** for an academic topic.

1 mark — Early estimates and later, industry-revised estimates differ by **enormous margins** (in one case by a factor of forty), making the dispute **prominent and contentious**.

Q15. [2] — Sweden vs Singapore

1 mark — Sweden’s electricity grid is largely **hydroelectric** / from a **low-carbon source**, so the energy used in streaming produces **very little carbon dioxide**.

1 mark — Singapore’s grid relies heavily on **natural gas and coal**, which are **fossil fuels**, so the same amount of electricity carries a **much higher carbon cost**.

Q16. [2] — Inverted commas on “background”

1 mark — The inverted commas signal that the writer is using the word in a **special** / **non-literal** sense — he is **picking out a particular kind of streaming** (one that nobody is actively watching).

1 mark — They also suggest a degree of **irony** or **implicit criticism**: streaming meant to be merely “in the background” still consumes real energy, and the casual label **disguises the real cost**.

Q17. [2] — Two trends driving demand (own words)

1 mark — Viewers increasingly demand **higher-resolution** video (HD and Ultra-HD / 4K), which uses **much more data per minute** than standard definition.

1 mark — A great deal of streaming now happens **without an active viewer** — televisions, music services, or tablets are left running while no one is paying attention, **wasting energy**.

Reject lifts of “background” / “lion’s share” without rewording.

Q18. [2] — “Swallowed” by growth in demand

1 mark — **Swallowed** is a **metaphor**: the efficiency gains have been **completely absorbed / consumed / cancelled out** by the rising demand.

1 mark — Although each minute of streaming is now less polluting, the **total number of minutes** streamed has grown so quickly that the **overall carbon output** has continued to **rise**, not fall.

Q19. [2] — “Almost embarrassingly small” choices

1 mark — The writer acknowledges that the individual changes (smaller screen, lower resolution, no autoplay) feel **trivial / too minor to matter** on their own.

1 mark — He believes, however, that when **repeated across millions of households**, even very small individual choices add up to a **meaningful collective impact** — so he does not dismiss them, only their appearance.

Q20. [2] — Why he is confident the changes are achievable (own words / justify)

1 mark — The **technology already exists**: codecs, lower default resolutions, autoplay redesigns, and efficiency standards for chips and cooling are all within current engineering capability.

1 mark — What is lacking is not technical capability but **political will and public pressure** — i.e. the obstacles are **social**, not **scientific**, and therefore in principle removable.

Q21. [2] — Purpose of the contrast with flights, petrol engines and burgers

1 mark — The contrast shows that other polluting activities have **visible, audible, or tangible reminders** of their environmental cost (vapour, noise, packaging), which prompt people to think about them.

1 mark — Streaming, by contrast, has **no such cues**; the contrast underlines **why** its carbon cost remains **under-reported and under-recognised**.

Q22. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one of**: **critical, gently chiding, admonishing, concerned, cautionary**. (Reject: **angry, hopeful** — these miss the measured, reproachful quality.)

Q23. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Why streaming has a significant and growing carbon cost (Paragraphs 3–4):

1. **Global data-centre electricity use has roughly doubled** in the last decade, with streaming accounting for the majority of internet traffic.
2. Viewers demand **ever higher resolutions** (HD and 4K), which use **much more data** than standard definition.
3. A large share of streaming is **unwatched / running in the background** (TVs, music, auto-playing tablets), wasting energy on nobody.
4. **Efficiency improvements** by platforms have been **outpaced** by the much larger growth in total streaming demand, so absolute emissions keep rising.

What can be done by individuals and by companies/governments (Paragraphs 5–6):

5. Individuals can watch on **smaller devices** / select **lower resolutions** / avoid **streaming as background noise**.
6. Individuals can **download frequently watched content** instead of re-streaming it, and **disable autoplay**.
7. **Platforms** could **default to lower resolutions**, **disclose carbon costs** per title, and **redesign autoplay** to stop when attention has wandered.
8. **Governments** could require data centres to be built on **low-carbon grids** and set **efficiency standards** for the chips and cooling systems they use.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Streaming carries a significant carbon cost because data-centre electricity use has doubled, viewers expect ever higher resolutions, and much streaming runs unwatched in the background. Platforms' efficiency gains have been outpaced by surging demand. Viewers can help by choosing smaller screens, lower resolutions, downloading favourites and disabling autoplay. Companies should default to lower resolutions, disclose each title's carbon cost and redesign autoplay; governments should site data centres on cleaner grids and set strict equipment efficiency standards.

Length count: 78 words from "Streaming" onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —